

Cambridge IGCSE® (9–1)

SET E

FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH

0990/01

Paper 1 Reading

INSERT

2 hours

INFORMATION

- This insert contains the reading texts.
- You may annotate this insert and use the blank spaces for planning. **Do not write your answers** on the insert.

Read **Text A**, and then answer **Questions 1(a)–1(e)** on the question paper.

**Text A: A German Circus Uses Stunning Holograms
Instead of Live Animal Performers**

This text is an article about a German circus that has replaced live animals with hologram in its shows.

At performances of Circus Roncalli in Germany, an elephant stands before the audience, its ears flapping and trunk wagging. It hoists up its hind legs as the crowd applauds. Then it disappears. The elephant, along with horses and (bizarrely) a goldfish, is a 3-D hologram—a tech-savvy effort to preserve the flavour of historic circuses while eliminating concerns of animal cruelty.

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Circus Roncalli was founded in 1976 and began phasing out animal performances in the 1990s. Since 2018, the show has featured no live animals, turning instead to holographic projections with 360-degree visibility for spectators seated around the ring; it takes 11 projectors to pull off the feat.

Some of the holographic acts replicate traditional circus fare, like the performing elephant and an ethereal ring of horses that gallops around the big top. Other acts are more fantastical; circus-goers of the past, for instance, would not have been treated to the sight of a huge goldfish hovering in the middle of the ring.

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Once a mainstay of popular entertainment, circuses have been struggling in recent years. A number of factors have driven that decline, including the emergence of other media, like movies and video games, that compete for the young audiences' attention, and the increased cost of transporting a gaggle of performers and animals by train. (In 2016, when Circus Roncalli still used some animals, a single trip could cost them almost £70,000).

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But reports of horrifying animal cruelty played a role in damaging the circus' reputation. In 2015, Roncalli announced it will phase out its elephants, citing a "mood shift" among consumers. A new law in the UK, known as The Wild Animals in Circuses Bill, also means circuses will no longer be able to use wild animals as part of a travelling circus, with the government saying this has 'no place in modern society'.

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Circus owners, however, disagree; William Kerwich of the Cirque Royal defends the practice as a "tradition" and accused officials of playing politics "to get votes in elections." Since the UK ban, circus owners have seen a decline in ticket sales, suggesting the public is disappointed to see elephants and other wild animals go.

Another circus owner argued: "When people see animals in circuses they learn about them – sometimes it's the only chance they get to see these creatures up-close. They can also see for themselves how well we look after them. In fact, circus animals receive food, shelter and veterinary care. The average life expectancy of a tiger in captivity is 26 years compared to just 15 in the wild."

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Read **Text B**, and then answer **Question 1(f)** on the question paper.

Text B: Review of *'Twas the Night Before* by Cirque du Soleil

This text is a review of a circus show called *'Twas the Night Before*

We all know it. At least parts of it. *'Twas the Night Before Christmas* originally titled *A Visit from St. Nicholas* by Clement Clarke Moore. The poem first published in 1823 became an instant classic. It is the basis for all that we have come to think of as Santa - the reindeers, the chimney, dressed in red, all of it. It is read throughout the country in homes and churches and libraries and schools. That little old elf has become a part of our folklore, ingrained into every child's imagination. 5

And now Cirque du Soleil has reinvented the story with acrobats and jugglers and magicians and gravity-defying humans as well as spectacular roller skating, dancing, music, lights, sets, and costumes - you will be awed. A smile smashed across your face, you will clap and cheer and wish that this was not just 77 minutes long but forever long. 10

We follow Isabelle who as a teenager is totally bored by her father reading the traditional story to her. Her father, clearly upset by her boredom, slams the book shut and with that, a storm erupts conjuring spritely creatures of snow and fun who whisk Isabelle to another world and her father in a search for his child. The two of them embark on special journeys; journeys only Cirque du Soleil could imagine. 15

What we humans are capable of doing with our physical selves, our defiance of gravity is astonishing. Each performance builds and builds becoming more and more eyes-wide-open, jaw-dropping feats of daring and beauty. And the clown work is so wonderful, so unlike what we expect of the traditional clown. 20

Along the way, Isabelle finds a renewed love of the story of Santa and her own kind of magic.

Read **Text C**, and then answer **Questions 2(a)–(d)** and **Question 3** on the question paper.

Text C: The Night Circus

This text is taken from a longer narrative. At his point in the story, a mysterious circus has arrived in town, much to the intrigue of the local people.

The circus arrives without warning.

No announcements precede it, no paper notices on downtown posts and billboards, no mentions or advertisements in local newspapers. It is simply there, when yesterday it was not.

The towering tents are striped in white and black, no golds and crimsons to be seen. No colour at all, save for the neighbouring trees and the grass of the surrounding fields. Black-and-white stripes on grey sky; countless tents of varying shapes and sizes, with an elaborate wrought-iron fence encasing them in a colourless world. Even what little ground is visible from outside is black or white, painted or powdered, or treated with some other circus trick.

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But it is not open for business. Not just yet.

Within hours everyone in town has heard about it. By afternoon the news has spread several towns over. Word of mouth is a more effective method of advertisement than typeset words and exclamation points on paper pamphlets or posters. It is impressive and unusual news, the sudden appearance of a mysterious circus. People marvel at the staggering height of the tallest tents. They stare at the clock that sits just inside the gates that no one can properly describe.

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And the black sign painted in white letters that hangs upon the gates, the one that reads:

*Opens at Nightfall
Closes at Dawn*

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"What kind of circus is only open at night?" people ask. No one has a proper answer, yet as dusk approaches there is a substantial crowd of spectators gathering outside the gates.

You are amongst them, of course. Your curiosity got the better of you, as curiosity is wont to do. You stand in the fading light, the scarf around your neck pulled up against the chilly evening breeze, waiting to see for yourself exactly what kind of circus only opens once the sun sets.

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The ticket booth clearly visible behind the gates is closed and barred. The tents are still, save for when they ripple ever so slightly in the wind. The only movement within the circus is the clock that ticks by the passing minutes, if such a wonder of sculpture can even be called a clock.

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The circus looks abandoned and empty. But you think perhaps you can smell caramel wafting through the evening breeze, beneath the crisp scent of the autumn leaves. A subtle sweetness at the edges of the cold.

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The sun disappears completely beyond the horizon, and the remaining luminosity shifts from dusk to twilight. The people around you are growing restless from waiting, a sea of shuffling feet, murmuring about abandoning the endeavour in search of someplace warmer to pass the evening. You yourself are debating departing when it happens. 40

First, there is a popping sound. It is barely audible over the wind and conversation. A soft noise like a kettle about to boil for tea. Then comes the light. All over the tents, small lights begin to flicker, as though the entirety of the circus is covered in particularly bright fireflies. The waiting crowd quiets as it watches this display of illumination. Someone near you gasps. A small child claps his hands with glee at the sight. When the tents are all aglow, sparkling against the night sky, the sign appears. 45

Stretched across the top of the gates, hidden in curls of iron, more firefly-like lights flicker to life. They pop as they brighten, some accompanied by a shower of glowing white sparks and a bit of smoke. The people nearest to the gates take a few steps back. 50

At first, it is only a random pattern of lights. But as more of them ignite, it becomes clear that they are aligned in scripted letters. First a *C* is distinguishable, followed by more letters. A *q*, oddly, and several *e*'s. When the final bulb pops alight, and the smoke and sparks dissipate, it is finally legible, this elaborate incandescent sign. Leaning to your left to gain a better view, you can see that it reads: 55

Le Cirque des Reves

Some in the crowd smile knowingly, while others frown and look questioningly at their neighbours. A child near you tugs on her mother's sleeve, begging to know what it says. "The Circus of Dreams," comes the reply. The girl smiles delightedly. Then the iron gates shudder and unlock, seemingly by their own volition. They swing outward, inviting the crowd inside. 60

Now the circus is open.
Now you may enter.



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